

GE 111

GENDER AND

SOCIETY



LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Articulate gender and sexuality across time; and
- Understand the context of gender and sexuality across time
- Show appreciation of how this understanding evolves through time, affected various aspects of human life.
- Discuss the historical roots of our understanding of gender and sexuality

Introduction

Society has progressed so much in a way that information and knowledge is available to everyone. This gives us an opportunity to examine our social and political conditions in more than when information was scarce and limited to only a few individuals.

Historical accounts show that across time, human conception of gender and sexuality has also changed. Archaeological artifacts reveal that in the distant past, during the dawn of civilization, human societies have high regard for women. The concept of the **divine feminine** (the sacredness of the woman to her ability to conceive children) has prevailed and thus, women are treated equally with men. This makes societies **egalitarian** (men and women have equitable power and roles).

However, humans' discovery of **paternity** (fatherhood/role of the father in conception), presumably during the Agricultural era, when societies began to establish communities and tame rear cattle and stocks, have also changed how societies viewed women and men therefrom.

For the longest time thereafter, societies have privileged men over other genders, mainly because of the preferential given to them in the **productive** sphere (world of public work).

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For the longest time thereafter, societies have privileged men over other genders, mainly because of the preferential given to them in the **productive** sphere (world of public work). Women who have been revered to their ability to conceive have been viewed as solely capable only of **reproductive** affairs (world of the home and related tasks such as suckling the young, child rearing, and home management). The gender disparity was intensified by the industrial era where factories were built and men were preferred because they did not have to bear children for nine months and because of their perceived physical strength. This lesson tackles movements in history which shows how men, women, and people of other genders are viewed in human societies.

Lecture Notes / Lesson Content

PATRIARCHY

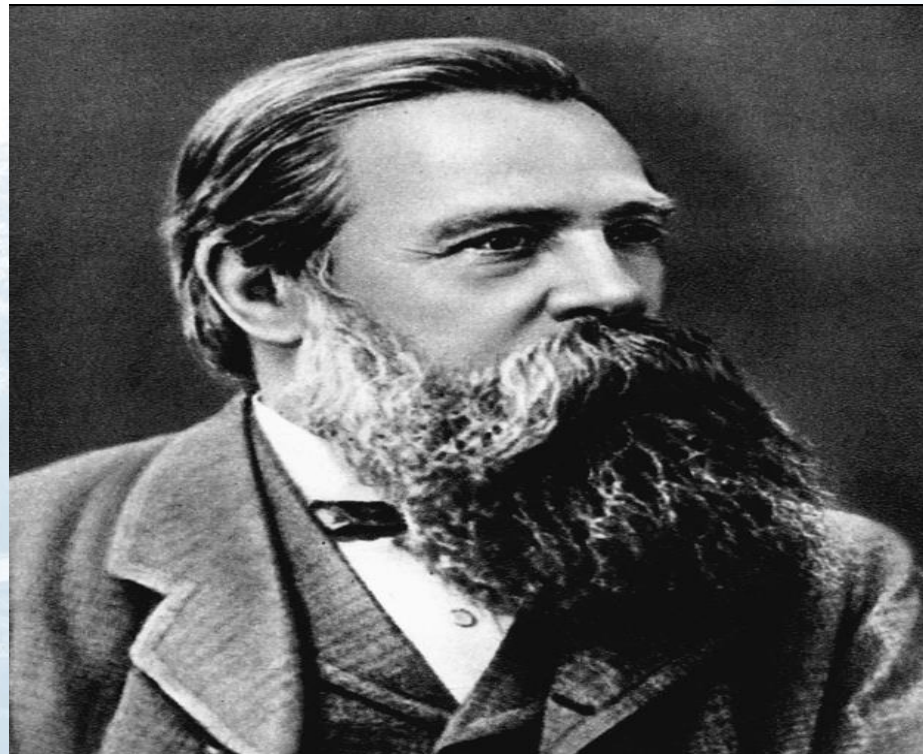
A close examination of our society can lead us to see the invisible layers of oppression in our society like patriarchy - a system based on the control and oppression of women wherein they are perceived to be the weaker sex. It is a structure that upholds male supremacy in the law, at home, in the work place, and in society.

Patriarchy is from the Greek word Patriarkhes which means "the rule of the father". It is a social system where men primarily holds power in the political and the private spheres. This means that in this social system, society is organized and maintained in a way that men rule over women and their children. In the social, legal, political, and economic spheres, men are expected

to lead while women are expected to obey and are relegated to house chores, bearing children, and child care.

A patrilineal society often follows a patriarchal society, this means only men can inherit property and the family name, Women were left with no inheritance and are expected to marry a man who can support her economically. In fact, women were not allowed to go to schools, or even vote, because they are viewed as a weaker sex and should not concern themselves in learning science or politics. Women had to fight for the right to vote, to go to school, to go to work, and even participate in politics.

Patriarchy is viewed by most sociologists as a social construct and not as a biological phenomenon. This is because history proves that in the prehistoric hunter-gatherer tribes and civilization, they prioritized equality of all members, male and female. History suggests an egalitarian system rather than a patriarchal system. Men and women contribute to society, and they enjoy the same social status.



Friedrich Engels, a German philosopher and sociologist, argues that patriarchy came about when people started having private property instead of a communal living. The development in agriculture and domestication of animals led to creating product surplus which allows people to have private property. As a way to control the excess wealth generated by these advancements, male dominance was asserted over women so only the male heir can inherit family wealth.

HISTORICAL VIEWS ON GENDER

Greek

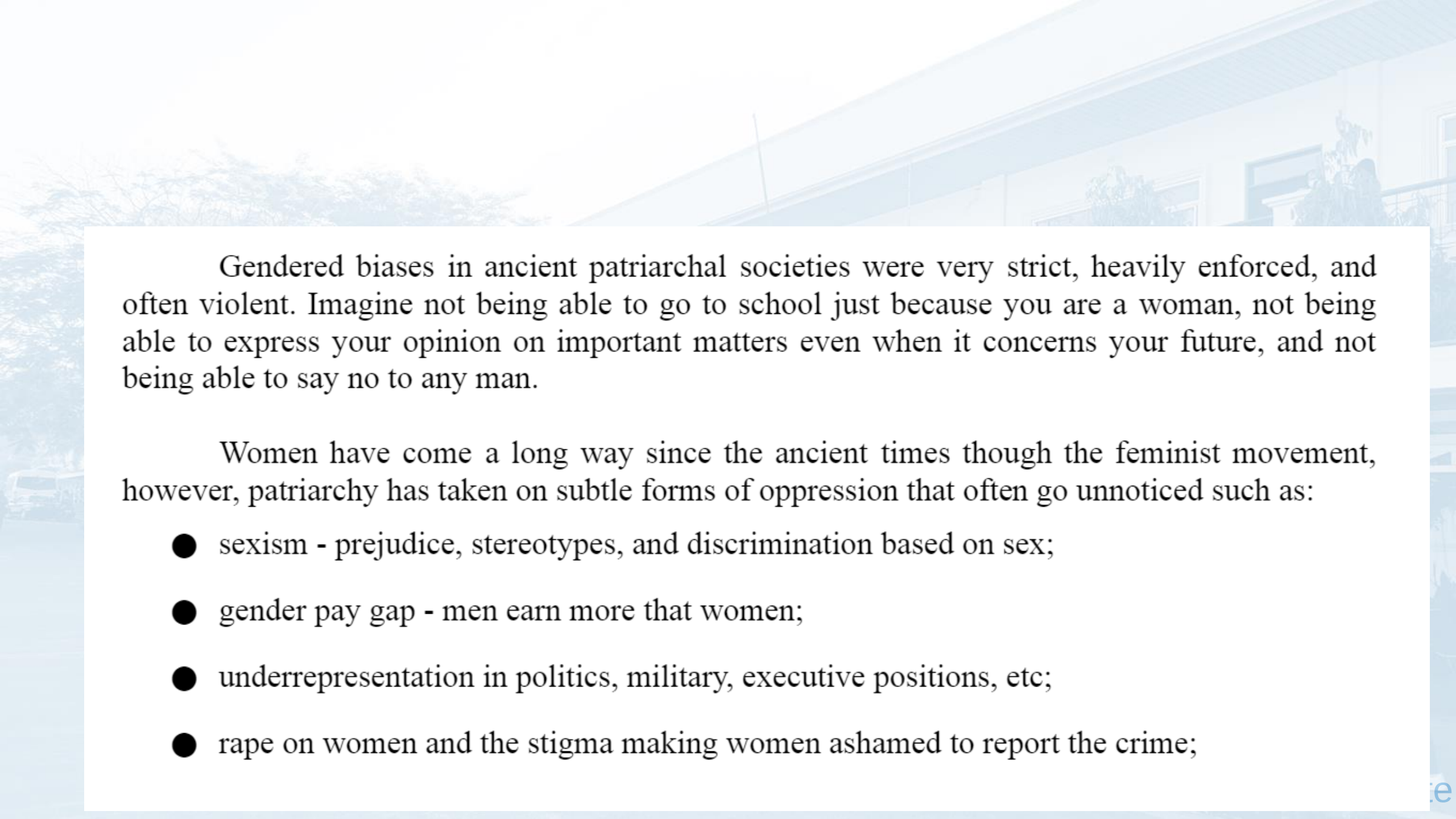
Aristotle, Plato, and other Greek philosophers viewed women as the inferior sex and are properties of men whose only job was to obey their husbands, bear children, and take care of the household. They were forbidden to learn philosophy, politics, and science.

Egypt

Herodotus, a Greek historian, observed the Egyptian civilization citing that Egyptian women enjoyed higher social status than Greek women because they can inherit property and engage in trade and politics. However, Greek influence quickly spread in Egypt through the conquests of Alexander the Great across Asia and Africa.

China

Confucianism has stringent written rules that dictate how women should conduct themselves. The written documents titled "Three obedience's and four virtues" and "Precepts of women" states that women should obey their father, when married she is to obey her son.



Gendered biases in ancient patriarchal societies were very strict, heavily enforced, and often violent. Imagine not being able to go to school just because you are a woman, not being able to express your opinion on important matters even when it concerns your future, and not being able to say no to any man.

Women have come a long way since the ancient times though the feminist movement, however, patriarchy has taken on subtle forms of oppression that often go unnoticed such as:

- sexism - prejudice, stereotypes, and discrimination based on sex;
- gender pay gap - men earn more than women;
- underrepresentation in politics, military, executive positions, etc;
- rape on women and the stigma making women ashamed to report the crime;

- very conservative expectations on women on how they behave;
- unrealistic depictions of women in fiction, often very sexualized:
- women do more housework and childcare;
- boys were trained to be leaders while women were trained to do house chores.



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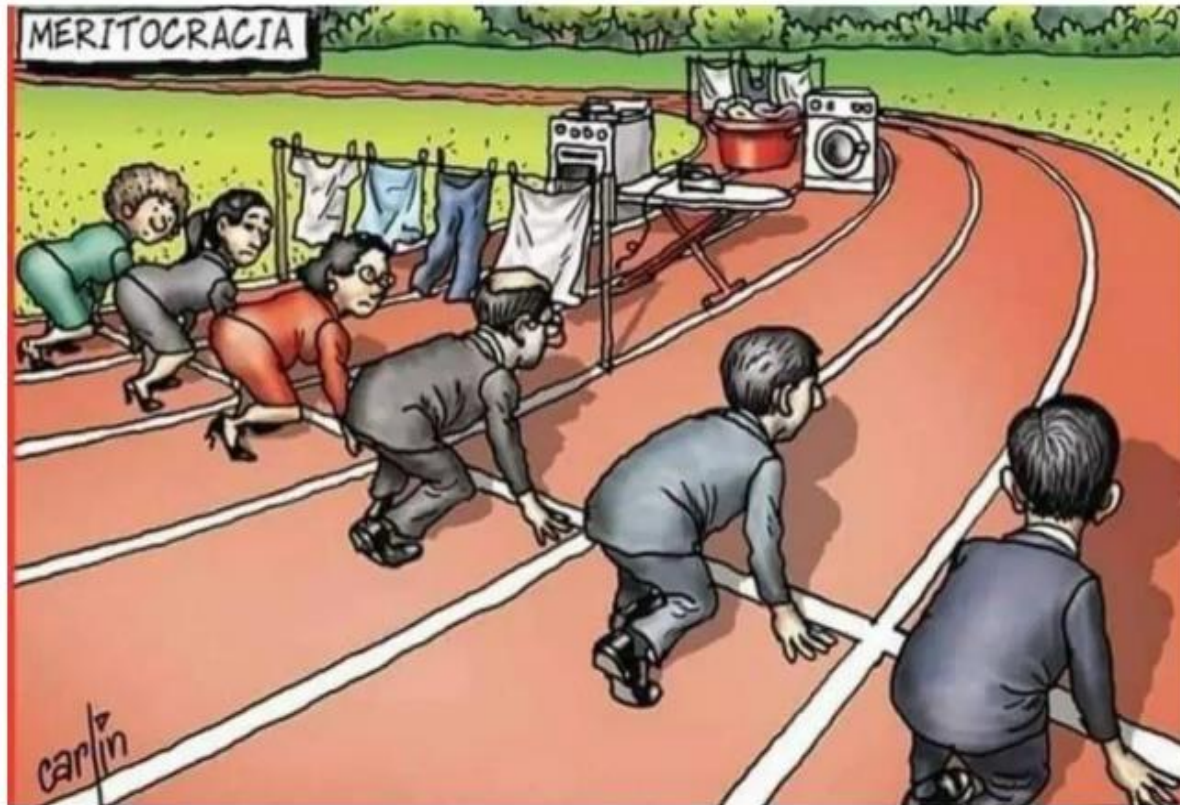
Unrealistic depictions of women on how they behave



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Boys were trained to be leaders while women were trained to do house work



WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

Women liberation movement, women movement, or feminism is a continuing series of social movement that aim to challenge the patriarchal society that creates these oppressive political structures, beliefs, and practices against women. It started at different decades in different countries, some are far more advance in their struggle while others are starting a movement. During the 19th and early 20th century, first-wave feminism spread the western countries as women demanded for their right so vote or participate in elections and to be able to legally own property.

In France, Simone de Beauvoir wrote book titled "The Second Sex in 1949. It outlined how the patriarchal society disadvantaged women by slowly raising her into submission and hindering their productivity and happiness by relegating them to housecleaning. This inspired many women to write and speak their truths, such as Betty Friedan (The Feminine Mystique, 1963), Kate Millet (Sexual Politics, 1969), and Germaine Greer (The Female Eunuch, 1970). Beauvoir's book was instrumental in awakening women about their plight as the "wife-servant" to their husbands in her famous quote "one is not born, but rather becomes, a woman."



Le Mouvement de Liberation des Femmes or the women's liberation movement was formed in Europe and they sought the right to education, right to work, and right to vote in the 1940s. Later, they also won women's right to decide on their own bodies and their sexualities. This liberation movement views the intersectionality of economic status or class to patriarchy.

Inspired by Beauvoir's book, second-wave feminism in 1960's through the 80's, women drew attention to various social and cultural inequalities such as domestic violence especially marital rape, reproductive rights, wage inequality, and etc. The 90's gave birth to the 3rd wave and 2012 started the forth wave. These movements only show that there is still much to be done for women's rights.

The United Nations reports that women do more work than men because even when they work at the office, they are still expected to do household tasks. Another report from UN Women stated that “women performs 66 percent of the worlds work, produce 50 percent of the food, but earn 10 of the income and own 1 percent of the property. This is because in agricultural countries, women participate in making the produce, but only the father or the male head of the family controls the income.





By freeing future generations of women from constant child-rearing, Sanger opened up new opportunities for women and set the feminist movement in motion.





People



56%

think it's acceptable for men
to have extra-marital affairs,
but not women



Oct. 2013 survey among men and women in the National Capital Region





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1. Women Suffrage – women were not allowed to vote before because they were viewed as irrational and temperamental and therefore not able to make rational decisions. This was changed after World war I (1914 to 1980] wherein women were uprooted from the household. They took on jobs and made significant contributions to their country.
 2. Equality in politics and society- for hundreds of years, women's voices were silenced, so society must make an effort to restore their rights.
 3. Reproductive rights means the woman is in control of her body, and she can decide for herself on what she sees is best for her. Contraception, abortion, and other reproductive options should be available to women because it is their body.
 4. Domestic violence- such as marital rape and physical abuse are often dismissed by society as a part of "marriage". Although we have RA 9262 or Anti Violence Against Women and their Children, our culture still dismiss such incidents "as away mag-asawa".
 5. Sexual harassment and sexual violence- The Center for Women's Resources in the Philippines estimates that one woman or child is raped every hour mostly by someone they know.
 6. Other rights include the right to divorce their husbands, the right to make decisions on her pregnancy, equitable wages, and equal employment opportunity.



Summary

Recognizing patriarchy in the simple things we do is very important for us to identify these instances so we can change it. Even the simplest acts that are seemingly harmless can be analyzed and seen as a way to force women into submission and compliance. That is the power of putting labels on oppressive acts, and you can call it out and stop it.

Feminism gained women access to education, right to vote, right to work, take control of their reproduction, and the right to say no instead of just obeying. However, there is still much to be done for gender equality.

You can help in making the world a better place for women by learning to respect and recognizing that women deserve the same rights as men-that women are not to be treated as the weaker sex or the submissive sex, but rather as an equal.



Also, use gender neutral language that is not sexist: humanity instead of mankind, the unsteady of he, to emphasize inclusion. You can also counter gendered metaphors by vocally criticizing its oppressive nature such as: the aggressive sperm and the passive e.g., *babae kase*, *lalake kase*, etc. You can also advocate for laws and policies that would empower women.

You do not have to be a woman to understand that everyone must be treated with the same respect and that everyone is free and equal in dignity and in rights.

Understanding the Lesson

Contemplate: Find a friend whom you are comfortable to discuss your thoughts. On your own, reflect on the following questions. Share ideas with them.



End

